e-market operated by an autonomous body with representation of progressive farmers and farmers' organisations. At present, private or government-owned commodity markets perform this function.

Down south, former Karnataka chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy often cites his concern for the farmers' welfare as the reason behind his Janata Dal (Secular) joining hands with the BJP and has made no secret of his desire to become the Union agriculture minister. Inking of this alliance did come in handy for coconut growers in the JD(S)'s pocket boroughs of Mandya and Hassan when, in mid-February, the Union government allowed the procurement of 7,000 tonnes of ball copra. The JD(S) had apparently pushed the issue keeping the election in mind.

In Odisha, which is going through simultaneous four-phase general and assembly elections, the Naveen Patnaik-led Biju Janata Dal (BJD) government has decided to extend its Krushak Assistance for Livelihood and Income Augmentation (KALIA) scheme for another three years. Running parallel to the PM Kisan scheme, it provides an additional Rs 4,000 annual assistance to farmers in two instalments for undertaking cultivation. In addition, eligible landless agricultural households get an annual support of Rs 12,500. Such schemes or promises may not always reap the desired dividends—the Bharat Rashtra Samithi's loss in last year's Telangana assembly election, for instance, even as its chief K. Chandrasekhar Rao had positioned himself as a guardian angel of farmers with his showpiece Rythu Bandhu Scheme. Around election time, however, each party keeps pushing the envelope.

BJP's Change of Tack

The Opposition may take potshots at the BJP regime for not fulfilling some of its commitments to farmers, but the latter has opted for a pragmatic approach that focuses on "doables" instead. Giving a silent burial to the much-touted '5F' formula, for instance, after it realised that the country's free trade agreements (FTAs) with ASEAN countries, which allow cheaper imports of raw material, leave no incentive for manufacturers to set up their units here. The finance and commerce ministries are already looking for duty restructuring to boost domestic production. In his May 11 rally at Odisha's Bargarh, Modi said that he was working tirelessly to facilitate the empowerment of farmers. The PM cited how the poor and costly supply of urea had remained a bane for the farmers under previous governments and how his regime was making it available for under Rs 300 per bag (50 kg).

All in all, the Centre in the past decade has put an emphasis on easing the input cost pressure on farmers, by streamlining access to seeds, good quality manure, urea and other chemicals, providing income support through PM Kisan, and improving access to irrigation and electricity to farms, along with deepening the penetration of banking and insurance in this vital sector. Agricultural credit expanded from Rs 7.3 lakh crore in 2013-14 to Rs 21.5 lakh crore in 2022-23. Many of the BJP-ruled states have given incentives over and above those provided under PM Kisan, the latest being Rajasthan, where the newly formed Bhajan Lal Sharma government has added Rs 2,000 to the Rs 6,000 transferred by the Centre into the farmers' accounts annually.

CONVENTIONALLY, THE FARMING COMMUNITY HAS NOT BEEN A BJP SUPPORTER. THAT'S WHY THE SAFFRON PARTY IS STRUGGLING TO CO-OPT THE JATS IN THE NORTH AND MOBILISE SUPPORT IN THE AGRARIAN BELTS OF PENINSULAR INDIA

But even as finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman talked of *aatmanirbharta* in oilseed production in her interim budget speech this year—which was also the BJP's promise in its 2019 manifesto—self-sufficiency remains elusive. There may have been progress in terms of the area under cultivation and yield of oilseeds and pulses since 2019, but the imports show no sign of tapering. In the 2022-23 marketing year (November-October), the country imported a record 16.44 million tonnes of edible oil, valued at Rs 1.38 lakh crore. In the case of pulses, almost 3 million tonnes were imported in 2023-24—the highest in six years. Pulses and oilseed growers are mainly concentrated in the Hindi belt of the country, and double up as the agrarian OBC voters. So, keeping them happy becomes all the more important for the BJP.

Conventionally, the farming community has not been a BJP supporter. That's the reason the party is struggling to co-opt the Jats in the North and mobilise support in agrarian belts of Maharashtra, Karnataka, Telangana and other states south of the Vindhyas. But in the past decade, PM Modi has overseen an effective outreach to the hitherto alienated communities via, what BJP leaders call, the *samagra samajik nyay*—or inclusive social justice. It is not only acting as a shield against the Congress's political agenda of committing to a caste census but is also helping the BJP break new ground. Come June 4, it will be hoping to reap a healthy harvest, overcoming the apparent discomfiture in the country's rural heartland. ■